



Global AI Trend Tracker

EQUITY: TECHNOLOGY

AI Expert Call #71 – China's SuperPod development

Quick Note

We hosted an AI Expert Call #71 on 6 August, featuring an expert in the domestic AI compute & networking market. The expert discussed SuperPod's (超节点) application scenarios, demand and shipment volume for SuperPod, differences in SuperPod technology between domestic and global players, and optical interconnect solutions. The following are our key takeaways from the call:

Domestic SuperPod application scenarios

- SuperPod plays a significant role in training, especially for training ultra-large AI models (trillion parameters). Domestic SuperPods were getting larger and larger, from 384, 540 to 1024, and even 8196 versions. For inference, SuperPod could help to improve cost-effectiveness, according to the expert.

Demand and current deployment volume for SuperPod

- As per the expert, currently, the leading domestic AI chips include Huawei (unlisted) Ascend 950, Hygon (688041 CH, Not rated) DCU3, and Cambricon (688256 CH, Not rated) MLU590, and single-card computing power can reach 1PFLOPS at FP8.
- Huawei's 384 SuperPod and Hygon's 640 SuperPod solutions were launched around three years earlier, and already a total of 200-300 units have been deployed, as per the expert. The new 1024-card SuperPods are still in the testing/validation phase, and if the yield rate could reach 50%-60% by 4Q26E, then shipments may start in 2027E, according to the expert.

Differences in SuperPod technology between domestic and global players

- According to the expert, NVIDIA (NVDA US, Not rated) adopted RoCE and Infiniband protocols, and optimized these protocols for AI computing, leading to high transmission efficiency of about 90-93% when applied in NVL SuperNod. The domestic competitors who are using the standard RoCE protocol, may have lower transmission efficiencies such as 50-60%, in view of the expert.
- Huawei's UB (unified bus) protocol is optimized upon RoCE protocol, achieving about 80% efficiency, and may even increase this to over 90% in the next one to two generations, according to the expert.

Optical interconnect solutions in SuperPod

- The expert noted the 384 SuperPod still uses a combination of copper cables and optical transceivers. The 384 solution has a two-layer structure (one spine layer), with 12 computing racks + 4 switching racks, and an optical transceiver ratio of 1:18.
- As per the expert, the 1024 SuperPod will start using the all-optical interconnect solution. The 1024 solution requires more than two spine layers, and the optical transceiver ratio ranges from 1:24 to 1:32, according to the expert. For the 8192 solution, three layers of spine are needed and the optical transceiver ratio will further increase, in view of the expert.

Development progress of domestic switches/switch chips

- The expert noted that network switches were all basically using domestic brands now in China. As per the expert, overseas players such as Broadcom (AVGO US, Not rated) and Cisco (CSCO US, Not rated) still have leading positions in switch chips,

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which can achieve a speed of 204.8T. HiSilicon's (unlisted) switch chips have already joined the leading camp, driven by high bandwidth and superior stability, according to the expert.

Appendix A-1

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